their indigenous struggle against the invaders and usurpers in their homeland.

In 2009, the politico-religious elements apparently started distancing themselves from the TTP, especially after the murder of Maulana Sarfraz Naeemi, a Lahore-based Barelvi cleric, who was killed in a suicide attack in Lahore for condemning the suicide attacks (Samaa TV, 2009). But surely they had not turned against TTP. They did not openly condemn their activities. Rather some religious elements, mostly belonging to Deobandi or Ahl-e-Hadith sects, had been persistently expressing or demonstrating sympathy for TTP.

In 2009, the general public also demonstrated a better understanding of TTP and the terrorist activities carried out by it.

> Even independent analysts have admitted that the Pakistan Army seemed to be winning the battle for Swat this time around. The reason stated has been simple: the 2009 military operation against the forces of fanaticism and extremism was whole heartedly supported by the masses (Mir, 2009).

Generally, letters to editors published in national dailies reflect the sentiments of the urban educated class in society. A brief look at the letters to editors published in *The News International*, given at Annexure F, mirror grave concerns of the public against the terrorists and their activities. People strongly believed that the terrorists had undermined their peaceful lifestyle and were causing a serious threat to their lives and properties.

Another poll result in 2009 showed that 81 per cent of Pakistanis believed the activities of the Taliban and other Muslim extremists a 'critical threat' to the country, up from the 34 per cent polled on the same question in September 2007. And 82 per cent said Al Qaeda was also a critical threat, exactly twice as many who thought so two years ago (*The Huffington Post*, 2009). Similarly, the International Republican Institute's poll showed that the number of people who did not approve of the US's 'war on terror' was reduced by 19 per cent from 89 per cent in January 2009 to 70 per cent in June 2009 (Christain Science Monitor, 2008). However, it was a short-lived reduction in sentiment against the US policies. The anti-US sentiments soon started to swell again and reached an unprecedented height following the Raymond Davis issue,